Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

- Document version: 1.0.0-beta, April-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1.
- Distributed at: https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
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1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- **`word`** - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- **`WORD`** - whitespace-delimited
- **`Ctrl-c`** - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- **`Alt-c`** - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- **`␣c`** is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars **`<regex>`**, **`<file>`** and **`<ch>`** represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- **`␣`**, **`<minus>`**, and **`<under>`** used for clarity. **`<enter>`**, **`<del>`**, **`<bksp>`**, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.3 Launching

- **`helix`**
- **`helix`** `<file>`
- **`helix`** `<file1> <file2> … <filen>`
- **`helix`** `–help`
- **`hx`** `in some distributions or by alias`

1.4 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

1.4.1 Example

```
v3wd
          v – enter select mode
          3 – select 3
          w – words
          d – delete
```

1.4.2 Samples

```
         wd – delete word
         xc – change line
         %y – yank entire file
```

1.5 Modes

As used in Helix documentation.

```
          : – command
          i – insert
          v – select or extend
          z – view - change view preserving selection
          g – goto
          m – match
     Ctrl-w – window
          ␣ – space
       [, ] – unimpaired
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

`u / U`	undo / redo change in linear history
`Alt-u / Alt-U`	move backward / forward in tree history
`:ear / :lat`	move backward / forward in history by step count or time span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
`<nn><cmd>`	repeat <cmd> <nn> times
`Esc`	return to normal mode

2.1.1 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

`:wq`	write current buffer and quit
`:wq <file>`	write current buffer to <file> and quit
`:wqa`	write all buffer(s) and quit
`:q`	quit current buffer, exits if last

2.1.2 Files

`:o <file>`	open <file> in new buffer
`:w <file>`	write current buffer to <file>
`:hs <file>`	open/create <file> in new horizontal split
`:vs <file>`	open/create <file> in new vertical split
`␣wf`	open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
`␣wF`	open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
`gf`	open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.
`␣f`	open file picker at LSP workspace root
`␣F`	open file picker at current working directory
`␣g`	open changed file picker

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

`<enter>`	open selected in current view
`Ctrl-s`	open selected in new horizontal split
`Ctrl-v`	open selected in new vertical split

2.1.3 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

`:n`	create new scratch buffer
`:bc`	close current buffer
`:bca`	close all buffers
`:bco`	close all but current buffer
`:bn`	next buffer
`␣b`	open buffer picker
`ga`	go to last accessed/alternate buffer
`gm`	go to last modified/alternate buffer
`gn`	go to next buffer
`gp`	go to previous buffer

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and `␣w` are synonymous.

`␣ws / ␣wv`	split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
`␣wns / ␣wnv`	split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
`␣wq`	close current split
`␣wo`	close all but current split
`␣ww`	next split
`␣wh/j/k/l`	move to buffer left / up / down / right
`␣wH/J/K/L`	swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
`␣wt`	transpose split

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

`Z`	enter sticky mode, exit with Esc
`zz, zc`	align to center
`zt`	align to top
`zb`	align to bottom
`zm`	align to middle horizontally
`zj`	scroll down
`zk`	scroll up

2.1.5 Help

`:tutor`	open tutorial
`␣?`	open command palette

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
      h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
       gh, g| – beginning of line
       <nn>g| – column <nn>
           gl – end of line
           gg – top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g – line <nn>
           ge – bottom of file
           gw – two-char labels on words, label to go
                to word

           g. – to last modification in current file
           gj – down textual line
           gk – up textual line

           gs – first non-white-space char
           gt – top of screen
           gc – middle of screen
           gb – bottom of screen
```

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol - Semantics

Requires LSP support.

```
gd – go to definition
gy – go to type definition
gr – go to references
gi – go to implementation

]d – next diagnostic
[d – prior diagnostic
]D – last diagnostic
[D – first diagnostic
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
]f, [f – to next, prior function
]t, [t – to next, prior type definition
]T, [T – to next, prior test
]a, [a – to next, prior arg
]c, [c – to next, prior comment
]g, [g – to next, prior change
]G, [G – to last, first change

Alt-e – move to end of parent node in syntax
        tree
Alt-b – move to start of parent node in syntax
        tree
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
Ctrl-b – page up
Ctrl-f – page down
Ctrl-u – half page up
Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
     % – select whole file
Alt-; – swap anchor and cursor
Alt-: – selection to normal direction (cursor at
        end)
Alt-o – expand selection syntax-aware
Alt-i – shrink selection
     ; – collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match around / inside the object
                  indicated by <ch> below:

          w / W – word / WORD
              p – paragraph
  (, [, ', etc.– specified surround pairs
              m –  closest surround pair
              f – function
              t – type or class
              a – argument/parameter
              c – comment
              T – test
              g – change git hunk
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
w / W – to start of next word / WORD
e / E – to end of current word / WORD
b / B – to start of current word / WORD
    x – current line, extend by line
    X – extend to line
Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
   ]p – to next paragraph
   [p – to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
Alt-o – expand selection to parent syntax node
Alt-i – shrink syntax tree object selection
Alt-p – select previous sibling node in syntax
        tree
Alt-n – select next sibling node in syntax tree
Alt-a – select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
Alt-I – select all children nodes in syntax tree
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find)
t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till)
      Alt-.  – repeat last find / till
```

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

`v`	toggle select mode
`Esc`	return to normal
`)`	cycle primary selection forward
`(`	cycle primary selection backward
`Alt-,`	remove primary selection

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

`s<regex>`	matches become selections
`S`	split on match
`Alt-s`	split on newlines
`C, Alt-C`	add selection below, above

2.5.2 Operations

`&`	align on primary cursor
`Alt-<minus>`	merge selections
`Alt-<under>`	merge consecutive selections
`,`	remove all except primary selection
`Alt-,`	remove primary selection
`( / )`	rotate primary backwards / forwards
`Alt-( / Alt-)`	rotate content backward / forward
`K`	keep selections matching the regex
`Alt-K`	remove selections matching the regex

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

`i`	before selection
`a`	after selection
`I`	at start of line
`A`	at end of line
`o`	add line and insert below cursor
`O`	add line and insert above cursor
`Esc`	end insert (return to normal)
`.`	repeat last insert

2.6.2 Add

`]␣`	newline below
`[␣`	newline above
`ms<ch>`	add delim <ch> around selection

2.6.3 Delete

`d`	selection -> yank buf, delete selection
`Alt-d`	delete, no save
`md<ch>`	delete delim <ch> around selection

2.6.4 Change

`c`	selection -> yank buf, change selection
`Alt-c`	change, no save
`=`	format by LSP
`mr<ch1><ch2>`	replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>

2.6.5 Indent Lines

`>`	Indent line(s) containing selection
`<`	Undent line(s) containing selection

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

`~`	change case
`` ` ``	set lowercase
`Alt-` `	set uppercase

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

`␣c, Ctrl-c`	Toggle comment
`␣C`	Toggle block comment
`␣Alt-C`	Toggle line comment

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

`Ctrl-a`	increment the selected number
`Ctrl-x`	decrement the selected number

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

`J`	join lines in a selection
`Alt-J`	join lines inside selection and select the inserted space
`<under>`	trim whitespace from selection

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

`y`	selection -> yank buf
`p`	paste yank buf after the cursor
`P`	paste yank buf before the cursor
`␣y`	yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
`␣Y`	yank main selection -> system clipboard
`␣p / ␣P`	paste clipboard after / before selections(s)
`␣R`	replace selection(s) with clipboard
`r<ch>`	replace selection with <ch>
`R`	replace selection with yank buf
`"`	select register to yank to or paste from

2.8 Search

`/<regex>`	search forward for regex
`?<regex>`	search backward for regex
`n, N`	next, previous match
`*`	search for current selection, respect word boundaries
`Alt-*`	search for current selection

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
"<ch>  – change to reg <ch>
"<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
"<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
"<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.10 Macros

```
"<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
"<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.11 Jumplists

```
Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
    ␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
         mm – go to matching delim
     mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
     ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
     ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
     md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
     | – replace selection(s) with output
  Alt-| – ignore output
     ! –  insert output before each selection(s)
  Alt-! –  append output after each selection(s)
     $ –  keep selection(s) where command
          returned 0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

```
␣G – debug - experimental
␣k – show documentation for item under
     cursor
␣s – open document symbol picker
␣S – open workspace symbol picker
␣d – open document diagnostics picker
␣D – open workspace diagnostics picker
␣r – rename symbol
␣a – apply code action
␣h – select symbol references for symbol
     under cursor
```

2.15 Editor Configuration

```
         :config-open – open the config file
:config-open-workspace – open the workspace
                         config file
       :config-reload – reload the config file
```

2.16 Miscellaneous

```
␣' – open last picker
␣/ – open global search in workspace folder
     picker
```

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

`Ctrl-s`	commit undo checkpoint
`Ctrl-x`	autocomplete
`Ctrl-r`	insert a register content
`Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp>`	delete previous word
`Alt-d, Alt-<del>`	delete next word
`Ctrl-u`	delete to start of line
`Ctrl-k`	delete to end of line
`Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp>`	delete previous char
`Ctrl-d, <del>`	delete next char
`Ctrl-j, <enter>`	insert new line
`<Up> <Down> <Left> <Right> <PageUp> <PageDown> <Home> <End>`	usual meaning but discouraged

3.2 Command Line Editing

`Esc, Ctrl-c`	close prompt
`<enter>`	open selected
`<tab>`	select next completion item
`<backtab>`	select previous completion item
`Alt-b`	backward a word
`Ctrl-b`	backward a char
`Alt-f`	forward a word
`Ctrl-f`	forward a char
`Ctrl-e`	to prompt end
`Ctrl-a`	to prompt start
`Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp>`	delete previous word
`Alt-d, Ctrl-<del>`	delete next word
`Ctrl-u`	delete to start of line
`Ctrl-k`	delete to end of line
`<bksp>, Ctrl-h`	delete previous char
`<del>, Ctrl-d`	delete next char
`Ctrl-s`	insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
`Ctrl-p`	select previous history
`Ctrl-n`	select next history
`Ctrl-r`	insert the content of the register selected by following input char

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

`Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up>`	previous entry
`<tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down>`	next entry
`<Home>`	to first entry
`<End>`	to last entry
`Ctrl-u, <PageUp>`	page up
`Ctrl-d, <PageDown>`	page down
`<enter>`	open selected
`Alt-<enter>`	open selected in the background without closing the picker
`Ctrl-s`	open horizontally
`Ctrl-v`	open vertically
`Ctrl-t`	toggle preview
`Esc, Ctrl-c`	close picker

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

`Ctrl-u`	scroll up
`Ctrl-d`	scroll down

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

`Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p`	previous entry
`Tab, Ctrl-n`	next entry
`<enter>`	close menu and accept completion
`Ctrl-c`	close menu and reject completion

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

`Alt-p`	previous signature
`Alt-n`	next signature

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- **Ctrl-e** – to prompt end **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-f** – forward a char **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-f** – page down **(2.2.4)**
- **Ctrl-h** – delete previous char **(3.1)**
- **Ctrl-h** – delete previous char **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-i** – move forward in jumplist **(2.11)**
- **Ctrl-j** – insert new line **(3.1)**
- **Ctrl-k** – delete to end of line **(3.1)**
- **Ctrl-k** – delete to end of line **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-n** – next entry **(3.3)**
- **Ctrl-n** – next entry **(3.5)**
- **Ctrl-n** – select next history **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-o** – move backwards in jumplist **(2.11)**
- **Ctrl-p** – previous entry **(3.3)**
- **Ctrl-p** – previous entry **(3.5)**
- **Ctrl-p** – select previous history **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-r** – insert a register content **(3.1)**
- **Ctrl-r** – insert the content of the register selected by following input char **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-s** – commit undo checkpoint **(3.1)**
- **Ctrl-s** – insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later) **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-s** – open horizontally **(3.3)**
- **Ctrl-s** – open selected in new horizontal split **(2.1.2.1)**
- **Ctrl-s** – save current position to jumplist **(2.11)**
- **Ctrl-t** – toggle preview **(3.3)**
- **Ctrl-u** – delete to start of line **(3.1)**
- **Ctrl-u** – delete to start of line **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-u** – half page up **(2.2.4)**
- **Ctrl-u** – page up **(3.3)**
- **Ctrl-u** – scroll up **(3.4)**
- **Ctrl-v** – open selected in new vertical split **(2.1.2.1)**
- **Ctrl-v** – open vertically **(3.3)**
- **Ctrl-w** – delete previous word **(3.1)**
- **Ctrl-w** – delete previous word **(3.2)**
- **Ctrl-x** – autocomplete **(3.1)**
- **Ctrl-x** – decrement the selected number **(2.6.8)**
- **Esc** – close picker **(3.3)**
- **Esc** – close prompt **(3.2)**
- **Esc** – end insert (return to normal) **(2.6.1)**
- **Esc** – return to normal **(2.4)**
- **Esc** – return to normal mode **(2.1)**
- **F<ch>** – to <ch> inclusive (find) **(2.3.5)**
- **I** – at start of line **(2.6.1)**
- **J** – join lines in a selection **(2.6.9)**
- **K** – keep selections matching the regex **(2.5.2)**
- **N** – next, previous match **(2.8)**
- **O** – add line and insert above cursor **(2.6.1)**
- **P** – paste yank buf before the cursor **(2.7)**
- **R** – replace selection with yank buf **(2.7)**
- **S** – split on match **(2.5.1)**
- **Shift-<bksp>** – delete previous char **(3.1)**
- **Shift-<tab>** – previous entry **(3.3)**
- **Shift-Tab** – previous entry **(3.5)**
- **T** – test **(2.3.2)**
- **T<ch>** – to <ch> exclusive (till) **(2.3.5)**
- **Tab** – next entry **(3.5)**
- **X** – extend to line **(2.3.3)**
- **Z** – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc **(2.1.4.1)**
- **[␣** – newline above **(2.6.2)**
- **[** – specified surround pairs **(2.3.2)**
- **[D** – first diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
- **[G** – to last, first change **(2.2.3)**
- **[T** – to next, prior test **(2.2.3)**
- **[a** – to next, prior arg **(2.2.3)**
- **[c** – to next, prior comment **(2.2.3)**
- **[d** – prior diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
- **[f** – to next, prior function **(2.2.3)**
- **[g** – to next, prior change **(2.2.3)**
- **[p** – to prior paragraph **(2.3.3)**
- **[t** – to next, prior type definition **(2.2.3)**
- **]␣** – newline below **(2.6.2)**
- **]D** – last diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
- **]G** – to last, first change **(2.2.3)**
- **]T** – to next, prior test **(2.2.3)**

- `]a` – to next, prior arg **(2.2.3)**
- `]c` – to next, prior comment **(2.2.3)**
- `]d` – next diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
- `]f` – to next, prior function **(2.2.3)**
- `]g` – to next, prior change **(2.2.3)**
- `]p` – to next paragraph **(2.3.3)**
- `]t` – to next, prior type definition **(2.2.3)**
- `` ` `` – set lowercase **(2.6.6)**
- `a` – after selection **(2.6.1)**
- `a` – argument/parameter **(2.3.2)**
- `b / B` – to start of current word / WORD **(2.3.3)**
- `c` – comment **(2.3.2)**
- `c` – selection -> yank buf, change selection **(2.6.4)**
- `d` – selection -> yank buf, delete selection **(2.6.3)**
- `e / E` – to end of current word / WORD **(2.3.3)**
- `etc.` – specified surround pairs **(2.3.2)**
- `f` – function **(2.3.2)**
- `f<ch>` – to <ch> inclusive (find) **(2.3.5)**
- `g` – change git hunk **(2.3.2)**
- `g.` – to last modification in current file **(2.2.1)**
- `g<nn>g` – line <nn> **(2.2.1)**
- `ga` – go to last accessed/alternate buffer **(2.1.3)**
- `gb` – bottom of screen **(2.2.1)**
- `gc` – middle of screen **(2.2.1)**
- `gd` – go to definition **(2.2.2)**
- `ge` – bottom of file **(2.2.1)**
- `gf` – open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection. **(2.1.2)**
- `gg` – top of file **(2.2.1)**
- `gh` – beginning of line **(2.2.1)**
- `gi` – go to implementation **(2.2.2)**
- `gj` – down textual line **(2.2.1)**
- `gk` – up textual line **(2.2.1)**
- `gl` – end of line **(2.2.1)**
- `gm` – go to last modified/alternate buffer **(2.1.3)**
- `gn` – go to next buffer **(2.1.3)**
- `gp` – go to previous buffer **(2.1.3)**
- `gr` – go to references **(2.2.2)**
- `gs` – first non-white-space char **(2.2.1)**
- `gt` – top of screen **(2.2.1)**
- `gw` – two-char labels on words, label to go to word **(2.2.1)**
- `gy` – go to type definition **(2.2.2)**
- `g|` – beginning of line **(2.2.1)**
- `h/j/k/l` – left / up / down / right **(2.2.1)**
- `i` – before selection **(2.6.1)**

- `m` – closest surround pair **(2.3.2)**
- `ma<ch>` – match around delim <ch> **(2.12)**
- `ma<ch> /` – match around / inside the object
- `mi<ch>` indicated by <ch> below: **(2.3.2)**
- `md<ch>` – delete delim <ch> around selection **(2.12)**
- `md<ch>` – delete delim <ch> around selection **(2.6.3)**
- `mi<ch>` – match inside delim <ch> **(2.12)**
- `mm` – go to matching delim **(2.12)**
- `mr<ch1><ch2>` – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2> **(2.12)**
- `mr<ch1><ch2>` – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2> **(2.6.4)**
- `ms<ch>` – add delim <ch> around selection **(2.12)**
- `ms<ch>` – add delim <ch> around selection **(2.6.2)**
- `n` – next, previous match **(2.8)**
- `o` – add line and insert below cursor **(2.6.1)**
- `p` – paragraph **(2.3.2)**
- `p` – paste yank buf after the cursor **(2.7)**
- `r<ch>` – replace selection with <ch> **(2.7)**
- `s<regex>` – matches become selections **(2.5.1)**
- `t` – type or class **(2.3.2)**
- `t<ch>` – to <ch> exclusive (till) **(2.3.5)**
- `u / U` – undo / redo change in linear history **(2.1)**
- `v` – toggle select mode **(2.4)**
- `w / W` – to start of next word / WORD **(2.3.3)**
- `w / W` – word / WORD **(2.3.2)**
- `x` – current line, extend by line **(2.3.3)**
- `y` – selection -> yank buf **(2.7)**
- `zb` – align to bottom **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zc` – align to center **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zj` – scroll down **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zk` – scroll up **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zm` – align to middle horizontally **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zt` – align to top **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zz` – align to center **(2.1.4.1)**
- `|` – replace selection(s) with output **(2.13)**
- `~` – change case **(2.6.6)**